kept her excitement hidden. “Is that possible?”

“Yes.” He smiled. “I could request that your cousin be transferred to Glashütte for similar work, but in a more conventional environment than in Berlin.”

“I don’t know what to say. I would be so grateful.”

“Consider it my Christmas gift to you.” He took a piece of paper. “I will see to it right away, if you agree. What is his full name?”

“André Simon.” She stood. The room was dimly lit, owing to another blackout, and the only source of light came from the flickering candles on the table. “Thank you, Herr Reinhardt. I think truly it was not a coincidence that we met all those months ago.”

“Eight months ago, to be precise.” He stood and came to her. “I consider us friends, please call me Kurt.” He reached into his pocket and pulled out a five-denomination Reichsmark note, holding it out for her.

The moment she touched the bill, she saw a predatory glint in his eyes. A warning told her to put an end to this, stop it now, don’t take his money, turn around and leave, but André’s life depended on what she did next, as did the well-being of the patients in the sick bay, so she pushed her unease to the back of her mind. “How long will it take to transfer him from Berlin to Glashütte?” she asked.

“The paperwork will take some time. It is December now, but if I move quickly, submitting all the necessary documentation by the end of the month, your cousin should be in Glashütte sometime in January, if everything goes smoothly.”

Rose’s heart skipped a beat.

“There is one thing I would like from you.”

“Yes?”

“Since we’re both orphans, you understand what it is to be without parents. Now, after losing Felix, I am completely alone and as you see from your interaction with Frau Birks, I feel as though others don’t understand me.” He stepped closer.

Rose stiffened. A ball of fear lodged in her throat. What would he ask of her? And if she refused, might she risk upsetting him and ruining André’s chance of escaping Berlin?

“I would like a private moment between us.” He held out his arms. “An embrace of friendship.” He hesitated, seemingly waiting for Rose to agree.